NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 5♦
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣K

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥10

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 2♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 8 4
♥ A J 3
♦ Q 10 6 5
♣ A K Q

♠ 5
♥ Q 10 9 8 2
♦ 9 2
♣ 9 8 6 5 4



♠ Q J 10 9 3
♥ K 7 6 4
♦ A
♣ J 10 3

♠ K 7 6 2
♥ 5
♦ K J 8 7 4 3
♣ 7 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♦	Pass	4♦
Pass	5♦		
All Pass			

5♦ by North
Lead: ♠Q

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 3♦. Partner now bids 4♦.

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Partner wouldn't bypass 3NT unless he was pretty distributional. His bid is invitational and you have excellent ♦ help so you try 5♦.

North plays 5♦. East leads the ♠Q.

You may be wishing partner had said 3NT. But at 3NT East might have led a ♥, then you'd be wishing you were in 5♦.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

This looks so easy let's check it by trying a winner count as well. Five ♦s (after ♦A is gone), the ♠ A K, the ♥A and the ♣ A K Q. Yes that adds up to 11 winners.

Is there ANY danger here at all?

Whenever a hand looks easy you should ask yourself what could go wrong. And here the only thing that could go wrong is if one of your ♠ winners gets ruffed. So how can you prevent that possibility?

If West has a singleton ♠, and East has the ♦A you might go down if you win the first trick in your hand. East will take his ♦A and play the ♠J. If you go up with dummy's ♠K West will ruff and you will still have a ♠ loser.

The simple solution is to win the first trick with dummy's ♠K. Now when East wins the ♦A and leads another ♠ it's a different situation. West may well ruff, but if he does you will just play a low card - West will have ruffed your ♠ **LOSER**.

You are a little unlucky that West has a singleton ♠.

But you are very lucky that you took the time to read this hand so you know how to play safely!

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 10 9 5 4
♥ J 8
♦ 9 5 3
♣ 10 9 6 5

♠ K 8 3 2
♥ 7 6 3
♦ A J 10 4
♣ A 4



♠ A J 6
♥ A Q 5 4
♦ K Q 8 2
♣ 7 3

♠ Q 7
♥ K 10 9 2
♦ 7 6
♣ K Q J 8 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♥	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♣K

= 8

You have 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit. To find a possible 4-4 fit you bid 2♣, the Stayman convention. Partner bids 2♥.

You have 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit. To find a possible 4-4 fit you bid 2♣, the Stayman convention. Partner bids 2♥.

You were hoping for a ♠ response, but so be it. You now bid 3NT, knowing partner will correct to 4♠ if he was 4-4 in the Majors, or pass if he doesn't have 4 ♠s. He passes.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT.

South leads the ♣K, North follows with the ♣10. Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 1 :: Total

It makes no difference whether you hold up or not, (unless their ♣s are 7-2), so go ahead and take the first trick.

Either the ♥Q or the ♠J **MIGHT** become your ninth trick.

If you try either finesse and it wins you will make your contract. If you try either finesse and it loses you will be set immediately with ♣s. Each finesse is a 50% shot.

Is there anything you can do to improve your chances?

Of course - otherwise the question wouldn't have been asked! You can combine two chances. Obviously you cannot take both finesses, but you can try to drop the ♠Q in two pulls, and if she doesn't drop you still have the ♥ finesse to fall back on. So win the ♣A, play 4 ♦ winners and the ♠ A K, then see whether you have to try the ♥ finesse.

Aha - the ♠Q dropped so you take your 9 tricks.

But if she hadn't, you'd still have a 50% chance in ♥s.

Board 3
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 7 3
♥ J 6
♦ A Q 7 6 2
♣ A 6 3

♠ Q 9 5
♥ 10 9 8 4 2
♦ K 8
♣ 10 5 4



♠ J 10 8 4
♥ K 7 5 3
♦ J 10 9 3
♣ 8

♠ K 6 2
♥ A Q
♦ 5 4
♣ K Q J 9 7 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	4♣	Pass	6♣
All Pass			

6♣ by South
Lead: ♥10

You are thinking slam; your first step is a jump to 3♣.

Partner says 4♣;

You are thinking slam; your first step is a jump to 3♣.

Partner says 4♣;

With partner agreeing ♣s, one possibility would be for you to cue-bid your ♥A. Another would be just to bid 6♣. You choose the second approach.

South plays 6♣. West leads the ♥10. East plays low and you win the ♥Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

Your best chance at another winner is the ♦ suit. West MAY have both the ♦ K Q, if not you will have to establish the suit.

At trick 2 pull just one round of trumps with the ♣K. Then play a small ♦, finessing the ♦J when West plays low. East takes the ♦Q and returns the ♠J.

Go up with your ♠K, you may need the entry to dummy later. Pull one more trump with the ♣Q, then play a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A. Ruff a ♦ with a high trump, West discarding.

Enter dummy with the ♣A, pulling West's last trump as you do, and ruff one more ♦, establishing the fifth ♦. Enter dummy with the ♠A and discard your losing ♠ on the good ♦.

It is important to be careful with entries to the hand where you are trying to establish a suit.

If the suit splits evenly perhaps you can be a little sloppy and still get by.

But in cases like this one, with a 4-2 split, you cannot afford to waste an entry too early.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q J 9 8 ♥ K J ♦ Q 9 8 5 ♣ Q J 3	
♠ A 10 5 2 ♥ 8 6 ♦ A K 3 ♣ A 9 6 2	N W E S	♠ 6 ♥ A 7 5 3 2 ♦ 7 6 4 2 ♣ 8 5 4
	♠ K 7 4 3 ♥ Q 10 9 4 ♦ J 10 ♣ K 10 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♦	Pass
2♥			
All Pass			

2♥ by West
Lead: ♠Q

This situation comes up a lot. You don't have enough points to advance partner's 1NT opening, but you have a "long suit" that might play better than notrump. If "long suit" is 6 ♥s or 6 ♠s then pretty clearly you should transfer partner to that suit and then pass. But with only 5 of the Major it is tougher to say that 1NT would be an inferior contract. Here's a suggestion - with fewer than 9 points and a 5-card Major, transfer to that suit when you have a singleton or void, otherwise pass 1NT. So here you bid 2♦ and partner says 2♥.

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Of course you pass, that was the whole point of the transfer.

The contract would be 2♥ played by East.

West plays 2♥. North leads the ♠Q, South playing the ♠7.

We will all agree that you win the first trick with your ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2/3/? : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = lots

In suit contracts it is usual to count losers. Sometimes in low level suit contracts it makes things clearer if you count winners. Here you have 4 high card winners in your hand plus the Ace of trumps in dummy.

Your plan will therefore be to make as many of dummy's small trumps as you can.

At trick 2 ruff a ♠ in dummy. Pull one trump with the ♥A. Play a ♣ back to your ♣A and ruff another ♠.

Got the idea? Play a ♦ to your ♦K and ruff your last ♠ in dummy. Then play the ♦A. If you've been counting you have taken the first 8 tricks. A good thing, too, because you aren't going to take any more.

In most suit contracts it is good to pull trumps early.

Here is an example of when that principle is **NOT** correct; when you need to get several ruffs with small trumps.